While noting this marriage, Abu'l Fazl takes care to point out that 'just as for other people more than one wife is not suitable, so for great persons more are necessary, so that their dwellings may be more splendid, and a large number of people may be supported'. For, as we have seen, Akbar had recommended in 1586 that a man should seek to have only one wife, unless his wife was barren. For kings and princes, a large number of wives and children were deemed necessary but apparently for others, marrying more than one wife 'ruins a man's health and disturbs the peace of the home'. A marriage was described as a sober and sacred union, essential for the good functioning of society:

> Every care bestowed upon this wonderful tie between men is a means of preserving the stability of the human race, and ensuring the progress of the world; it is a preventive against the outbreak of evil passions, and leads to the establishment of homes. Hence His Majesty, inasmuch as he is benign, watches over great and small, and imbues men with his notions of the spiritual union and the equality of essence which he sees in marriage.

As pointed out by scholar Rosalind O'Hanlon, through these regulations, Akbar 'aimed at promoting a particular model of ideal marriage, in which mature men could realize the ethic of imperial service, women enjoy peace and companionship, and homes fructify with children and sons to worship God'. This form of morally sanctioned marriage, bedrock to a stable society, could only promote sexual union for procreation, and there was no space for liaisons with women past menopause or pre-pubertal girls. Nor was there, indeed, license for homosexual love. Though various forms of homosexuality had been part of Hindustani and Timurid landscapes, it was now presented as a peculiarly Transoxianian malaise that sapped men's strength and undermined the proper functioning of society.

'Here in India,' continued Abu'l Fazl, 'where a man cannot see the woman to whom he is betrothed, there are peculiar obstacles; but His Majesty maintains that the consent of the bride and bridegroom, and the permission of the parents, are absolutely necessary in marriage contracts.' Through this decree Akbar seems to have been well aware of the coercive nature of some marriages and stressed the equal importance of all the concerned parties to the arrangement. Interestingly, Akbar disapproved of older women taking younger husbands, grumbling that it went against all